

MAIN IMAGE, REPRESSED NEEDS, AND DEFENSES --
LINKED CONFLICTS BEFORE CLARIFICATION

Greetings, my dearest friends. God bless you. God bless this hour. Many of my good friends find themselves in a state of inner struggle and crisis at this particular stage of their path and development. It is no coincidence that this happens at this time and to many of you. For, with the proper development and work, the nucleus of the inner problem is supposed to come to the surface more and more. Before overall understanding of the entire inner conflict is reached, just before all this is about to happen, provided you keep it up, you are bound to suffer from depression and confusion.

In the past, you may have gathered a considerable amount of insight. You may have gotten some understanding about isolated areas, about parts of problems, details. But you have not as yet gained the full, overall, and concise understanding of your life, what is problematic about it, and why. You still miss the main links, cause and effect. And before such understanding can be yours, you are bound to find in yourself a part that is putting up quite a struggle. Before your entire life, with its fulfillments and frustrations, can take on a new meaningfulness, you cannot help but go through a renewed confusion, as it were. It is this confusion that is mostly depressing. And the first step towards alleviating it is to become aware of exactly what you are confused about, rather than only feeling it vaguely.

It is said, and it is often true indeed, that the child in you resists growth, desires to remain immature and burdened with the unworkable wrong conclusions and destructive defense mechanisms. Without these pseudosolutions and defenses, a part in you believes itself lost, threatened, endangered. To let go the very "protection," or that which seems as such to you, causes the psyche to resist. Yet, such states as many of you are now going through are not due entirely to this resistance to growth and change, to the fear of letting go of familiar, although defective, behavior patterns.

Even if this particular kind of resistance has disappeared to a considerable degree, you still find yourself in a state outwardly resembling the fight against change. If this is so, it is due to discouragement with yourself, with your apparent relapses; and you do not understand why this occurs. This is part of the confusion I referred to earlier. These relapses occur not only because it takes considerable time until a new habit can form in your emotional reactions, but also because you cannot do so before you gain a fuller view and understanding regarding the totality of your conflicts. By this, I do not mean a general, theoretical understanding, but a real inner, specific, and personal understanding. Such inner understanding comes only after a great deal of deep insight and of growth and change regarding particular areas. All this is necessary before the nucleus can be affected.

In order to help you a little from outside towards this inner understanding so as to gain an overall picture about yourself, let me suggest to you an important link which will lead to the necessary insight and freedom. However, you must realize that any words spoken to you, coming to you from outside, can give you only theoretical understanding to begin with. It must not remain at that. You must use these words as guiding directives so as to gain personal, emotional understanding from them. The link must be made with your own findings, attitudes, and images.

Let us consider three major aspects of our work so far. To begin with, we were concerned with your images. As you know, there is always one main image which concerns the most important unfulfillment in your life. Therefore you go through repeated disappointments. In connection with the images, we deal with the various wrong conclusions and pseudosolutions which constitute a part of the main image.

The second aspect of our work deals with the repressed needs and, in connection with them, repressed emotions, positive and negative.

The third aspect deals with the defense mechanism you develop in order to obtain what seems to you a protection. In this category belong the attitudes of submissiveness, aggressiveness, withdrawal. These three aspects, as well as the idealized self-image, form a part of your defense. But it is more than all of this. The basic defense is a general inner climate that you have to come to feel. You have to recognize its presence in order to become fully aware of the damage it does to you. You have to acutely feel it almost as though it were a foreign body before you can convince yourself of its destructive influence, causing many unnecessary unfavorable results.

Let us now see how these three major aspects connect, how they are linked up with one another. Only if you have a full understanding of how this is so in your own individual case, will your confusion disappear, and then also your depression and discouragement -- an understanding that is not general, not theoretical, not in principle, but specifically as to how it applies to you!

Let us consider first, in brief review, how an image comes into existence. The childhood hurts and frustrations, which every child experiences at least to some degree, cause unhappiness and discontent. The situation that brings this about leads the child to jump to the erroneous conclusion that every similar situation is bound to bring a similar result. Thus what once was a reality now turns into illusion because it is untrue that such a generalization can be made. This generalization freezes into a rigid, preconceived idea. This then is the image. But a part of the image is the supposed remedy. Since the image is unreal, so must be the remedy. Since the image is an inflexible, rigid mass in the soul substance that should be fluid and dynamic, so must the remedy be unrealistic and therefore disappointing. All the more disappointing is the fact that what happens in reality is the very opposite function to that which it was supposed to fulfill. It goes without saying that this entire process is unconscious until you have succeeded in bringing it into your consciousness.

This predicament then results in further negative chain reactions. The defense mechanisms become stronger and stronger in every possible respect. The more this is so, the less it is possible to avoid the hurts that you have (unconsciously) labored so hard to forego. And so long as it is unconscious, you have no way of stopping this destructive process so entirely opposed to your own best interests.

In connection with that original hurt that caused you to form an image, you begin to repress. You not only repress this hurt so that you are no longer aware of it, but rather experience it as a vague, general climate, but you also repress many of your needs. This is so because the experience leading to your having formed an image was so painful and also so humiliating that you did not wish to face it. Also, the experience makes you believe that these needs cannot be fulfilled, and therefore you believe it possible to tear out your needs simply by not acknowledging them.

However, your pseudosolutions are supposed to bring you the fulfillment you often simultaneously deny, without any risks of being hurt or being humiliated again. Since this cannot be so, your defenses become stronger, and thereby fulfillment becomes less possible. During this process, you go on repressing your needs, your hurts, your disappointments. Oh, you may experience them to a certain degree, but rarely with the full impact and almost never with the understanding of what really hurts you and why.

This repeated pattern not only proves the image right, but it also proves that your defenses against it do not work. This increases the original hurt of the experience having brought the image into existence. This is all the more confusing because a part of the image works. The best way to explain this is by way of an example. Of course, the example can only be a simplified one because we cannot go into the many side effects and details that are important in an entire human personality. We will consider it now only from the standpoint of a discussion. But such an example may clarify a little better what I mean than a description in abstract terms.

Let us suppose a male child has had a cruel mother, or maybe not even really cruel, but it seemed that way to the child because she might have been inhibited, undemonstrative, conflicted, and she therefore lacked understanding and imagination. No matter, the child experienced an acute lack of affection, warmth, and understanding and was therefore frustrated. This was a reality situation. The image will form: "Women are ungiving, women reject and do not give love." Therefore fear, apprehension, and anxiety exists toward women when the child becomes an adult. This may outwardly be overcome, but if the emotions are examined, this will be found. But since the basic need for the opposite sex and the basic need for warmth, love, and affection cannot really be torn out, a remedy against this image will come into existence. As I said before, due to the unreal premise that all women are the way the mother was, so must the remedy be unreal and not effective.

Let us further assume that the same mother was quite demanding as far as work in school is concerned. She expected a high standard from the child. And when this child actually was successful, she approved. She was not withholding in her approval. She was then liberal with praise. Thus some kind of gratification could be had by the child, provided he struggled hard enough to be successful. This will further create the impression and add to the image the following conclusion: "Although women do not give the love and comfort my soul really craves for, I may get the next best thing. I may have some importance by being successful in my work."

Needless to say, such thoughts are not really uttered, even unconsciously. For unconsciously there is no clear-cut distinction between receiving love and receiving approval. It is only vaguely felt that something favorable came forth by being ambitious, while nothing favorable happened when not. And even when the approval came, there was no conscious lack of something. It was rather the inner climate that what one yearned for could be had to some degree if one makes efforts in

these certain directions. The real need for being loved was already repressed by the time the image came into existence.

Hence, the main image, in a case like this, would be: "I have to be successful in order to be loved," and "Approval for my professional work is one and the same as being loved." Images of this or similar sort are quite frequent. But let us now examine a little further, with our new understanding, what this means. Due to such an image, if there is no strong second image present, counteracting this one, such a person will actually be very successful. He will be ambitious and will use all his resources in order to satisfy the image claim to receive approval and success. This image claim will be granted. But the underlying claim, that approval is tantamount to love, cannot be granted because here lies the wrong conclusion. The actual image of striving for success is not in itself a wrong conclusion. It may be a waste of too much energy on one aspect of life at the expense of another which may be more important for happiness and peace. But in itself, there is no error, no untruth involved. It may be an imbalance when the entire life and its needs are considered, but in itself it is not based on a wrong assumption. Therefore it will work out. The claim for success will be fulfilled. Whether or not the overemphasis brings unbalance to the life of the person, in the claim itself there is no logical error. This will furnish you with the explanation for a question that constantly bothers some of my friends: why such and such a person who is so much less developed has this and that success which a more developed person lacks.

But the unconscious aim and claim for gaining love through success cannot be granted because approval and love are not the same. To believe it (consciously or unconsciously) is a logical error, a misconception, and therefore it cannot work. By gaining the one, you do not gain the other. If you gain love and success, it is due to a logically correct attitude towards both. This then is where the image does not work. This is why the constantly frustrated needs grow and are repressed because the personality is not willing to face (a) the longing and pain of the unfulfillment and (b) the erroneous image conclusion. The unfulfilled need for love, warmth, companionship, union is contained in the unpronounced claim of the main image. There you clearly see one link between the main image and the repressed needs.

The repressed need for love is in itself a healthy and legitimate need. But the need for approval at the expense of gaining love is an unhealthy need. Now why do I say "at the expense of?" Because if you concentrate on being successful, on impressing others, on receiving admiration -- which all falls under the category of approval -- you are bound to pursue the very behavior pattern that will push love away from you. That which you need most, but of which you are unaware, but which originally caused you to produce your main image, you reject because of the wrong conclusion involved. If any such person is loved nevertheless and the motives were investigated, it would prove that the loving person does not love because of the traits that are imbedded in this image and which bring the success. It will be so because he senses another quality behind and apart from the traits that are meant to make the image work.

Now let us go to the next step, with the same example I have chosen. Such a person may be aware of a drive for success. But he is unaware of why this is so important, where it stems from, and what the frustration and need behind it really mean. And therefore each time he reaps success without the unpronounced inner claim for love, it is not only a new frustration, it is the same hurt from childhood, experienced all over again, but it increases inner insecurity and inferiority. He originally deduced that if he were more loveable, his mother would have given him more of what he

needed. He, as a child, could not evaluate that his mother might have been incapable of feeling or demonstrating love. And now he is incapable of deducing that he himself forfeits love, not because he is unworthy of it, but because his very defense against being hurt is arrogant, rejecting, superior, and fearful. All these are feelings which do not inspire love.

Only by unrolling this entire process can the painful inferiority feeling disappear. It is this very inferiority, this very feeling of being unlovable that the soul resists to face. He fears what he will find will be "I am unlovable," so he represses. And while doing so, he not only represses this painful factor, but he also represses the entire process of image, needs, false claims, destructive defense mechanisms, together with all the traits of the idealized self-image and of the various pseudosolutions. But only by courageously going in and through this process will he find that he is actually not at all unlovable, but he makes himself so by his defense mechanism. This realization is one of the most important ones on the path. It holds true for everyone in some way, whatever the images are, whatever the idealized self-image is, whatever the various pseudosolutions are. Even if the pseudosolution is submissiveness, which seems so opposite to the arrogance of the aggressive success seeker and the pseudosolution that denies needs, it will always be found that deep within this submissiveness lies as much arrogance and superiority as in the other pseudosolutions. It is clothed in a seemingly more acceptable cloak, but it contains as hardened a defense structure as the extreme opposite. This defense structure is an invisible but very real wall unconsciously perceived by everyone, which prohibits love although it begs for it. Only upon close analysis of the various emotions and feelings contained in it, will it become clear that the submitter rejects as much as the aggressor.

The crisis and struggle preceding this important breakthrough is also based on the still unconscious confusion that the very means that are supposed to get love and acceptance actually do not bring it. Therefore the unconscious belief of one's own unworthiness increases, and this is even more difficult to face. If only you go through it, you will be relieved to see it is not you who is unlovable, but the various devices you use for your protection. This recognition is of untold value and will give you incredible strength.

The search in this direction is not easy. There are so many factors, so many simultaneously contradictory aspects to unroll and to see. There may be a moment's insight that only eludes you again. And when you then try to feel it by memory, it no longer works. It is no longer meaningful. It has to be found again until it takes a stronger hold of you. Only by repeatedly observing this destructive defense, how it feels in you, what it makes you do, feel, think, how it makes you react, how this affects others, only then will you see and truly understand. Only then will you gradually let go, become free of it, and only then will your true, "undefended" self manifest. It may often act completely against your known outer rules, your principles, your established patterns that you have become so used to. It takes a great deal of struggle until you let your real self act, unhampered by your outer levels which are so unreliable, as your life has shown you in your trouble.

Your innermost self, which knows so well, which will never lead you astray, cannot function so long as it is encased in the hardened, brittle structure of your defenses.

Another difficulty in your struggle to come through and see the light is the following confusion. Since everyone has a streak of submissiveness, you may confuse it with giving up your arrogance and superiority which forfeits love, just as you will confuse healthy self-assertion with this

very same superiority. The difference is subtle, difficult to put into words, but it is nevertheless a decided one. Yet, while you still find yourself so involved with your problems, it is hard for a while to perceive which is which. You struggle between two alternatives, either of which could be either healthy or distorted. You will find the answer only if and when you have found your point of relinquishing, and if and when you are utterly aware of the hardened mass of your defense mechanism.

Let us examine for a moment the difference between submissiveness, appeasement, and the unprotected, vulnerable real self which should be out in the open. And this does not mean more hurt, but less, my friends. When you appease or submit, when you give up or allow others to take advantage of you, you do so only because you cannot relinquish the claims of your needs and just because you are unaware of them. You bow down to your inability to give in, to lose. That robs you of the dignity of your real self. Your real self can lose. It may be painful, but never as painful and bitter as the struggle of straining towards the impossible.

You will not forfeit your dignity because you do not have to have. And you do not have to have if you can face your needs and face the fact of how you forfeited their fulfillment by the very process I am describing here. The stronger your tendency is to submit, the more self-contempt do you beget, and therefore the stronger is the pull into the opposite direction of arrogant aggressiveness, superiority. Whether you outwardly manifest it or whether it smolders hidden, it has its effect on others, and it rejects. However, you confuse it with the dignity that is lacking in your tendency to submit. Your submissiveness is an outcome of your repressed needs, of your denial and shame of them. Your aggressiveness is a defense not so much against outer hurts, but against your submissiveness.

In this conflict, you find yourself ensnared. You cannot give up the defense that keeps you chained to both these tendencies. Or if you are so confused between these two ways, you may resort to withdrawing from life, from love, from reaching out towards life and towards others. Again it is not so much that you withdraw because you fear others, but because you cannot cope between these two artificially constructed attitudes that unconsciously, at one time, seemed to be the solution.

All I told you now should not be mere words to you. As long as they are, they will not do you any good. Therefore it is necessary that you begin to link up these elements by reconsidering, once again, what your main image is. Some of you have not even found it yet. If you have not, consider your main problem, unhappiness, unfulfillment, and then proceed to find it. It will now be much easier to do so with all the preliminary work you have gone through.

Once you see the main image, determine the part that did work out because of its correct premise, in itself. And then consider the hidden claim and that it did not work. Consider the needs involved with this image. Even before you will feel them, you will know these needs must be there once you realize the image with each of the fulfilled and unfulfilled claims. This will enable you to set out feeling them, and you will become aware of them in due time. You will acutely feel the real, as well as the superimposed unreal needs. Simultaneously, train yourself to feel your defensive wall in yourself. Observe it in action. Feel its existence. It is there if only you pay attention to it.

Last but not least, begin to notice the difference in your behavior and reaction when you feel the defensive wall in you and when you do not. This will bring into clear focus the effect you must have on others. Without the awareness of this difference, you cannot know the effect of your defense. When you realize the effect you have on others due to this defense mechanism, you will then be able to close the circle and see that this defensive wall breeds the very unfulfillment you wanted to avoid through the erroneous image conclusion. You all get what the image demands, as long as there is no logical error contained in it. After establishing these facts, apart from the other part that is based on a misconception, you may change your inner weight and focus because you will recognize that it does not bring you what you really want.

Those of you who are aware of their main image, without the links I now showed, will not yet really benefit from this awareness. It will not be a live knowledge that has an impact on you, that enables you to go through an inner change. In order to do that, you need the connecting links in your personal inner history.

If there is anything that is not quite clear, please ask about it.

QUESTION: I realize that at this point of the path I use my defense mechanism and recognize it. I am aware of it. Instead of following through, I try not to act upon it. So I am going through a stage of holding my breath. I don't want to suppress it, I don't want to follow it out, and there am I. I can't go on. Can you give me a hint?

ANSWER: You are in this painful state because you still act upon obedience rather than recognition. You somehow know that the defense is destructive in general, and you obey this general understanding. But you have not seen yet why this defense is unnecessary, superfluous, and against your own interest in your particular case. Once you will have gained this insight, it will no longer be difficult to prevent yourself from acting it out because you will have no further need for it. The fact that you are suspended, so to speak, in the state you describe is due to your persisting inner conviction that you still need this defense. Therefore it now becomes imperative for you to find out why you think that you have need for this defense. There is a tremendous anxiety in you that without it, you will somehow be annihilated or threatened. Make conscious what it is you fear will happen to you without this defense.

What happens now is that you no longer wish to use it; therefore you hold it back forcefully. But you are not inwardly convinced you can dispense with it; therefore you forcefully still hold on to it. You try to compromise between the old and the new, not quite ready yet for the new, and yet a part of you is eager and willing for the new life. This painful state is one that many of you are now going through in one form or another. The clear recognition of it will not only alleviate some of the pain, but it will give you a clear directive as to how to go on from here.

Once you have found the need, you will be able to relax inwardly. All this is difficult to explain in words because we deal here with soul movements. We come into a realm here where words are very insufficient. Try to follow these movements, to visualize them. What you did before the recent findings was to press under in a hard, cramped downward movement. Then when the pressure became too much, you let it shoot out, but still in a tense, cramped motion. Both movements are tense and cramped, one pressing down, the other shooting out. The third alternative, after understanding how unnecessary and superfluous this protective measure is, apart

from its destructiveness, will be to relax this hardened mass that has either pressed down or struck out. Thus the hardened mass will dissolve and will then bring relief and release that is constructive and meaningful. The striking out movement also brought momentary relief, but in the long run of a destructive nature.

The first few times you try to dispense with the hardened wall, the cramped movement, either down or out, you may feel as though you were falling into an abyss. You will feel yourself defenseless. While before, your stronghold, your safe point was the hardened mass of your defense which necessitates either of the two hard movements. Without it, you felt vulnerable, attackable. If you realize that this is an error, you will be capable of softening up the hard mass. You are now trying to retain it without repression. But this is not yet what you really aim for. Instead of retaining it, you have to dissolve it by this relaxing, softening up process. In order to be able to do so, you have to ask yourself -- of your emotions, not of your brain -- the question: "What am I afraid of without the defense?" Find this answer. From there on, you will go further.

QUESTION: I have many of the symptoms you have explained here. But on the one hand, I am frightened, and on the other I feel an inner peace. So I don't know what to do. I feel both ways, often at the same time. I can translate my emotions very well, but I still need help in this respect. I think one part of my problem is that there is too much passivity in me, and that generates a certain fear too.

ANSWER: I could really only repeat what I said to you many times before. You have now reached a point where finally one part of you is beginning to want to give up childhood. When this is predominant, you feel the peace you describe. On the other hand, a part of you still holds on frantically to childhood, fears adulthood with its responsibility and what seems like activity to you. This struggle is now coming to the surface and to a head. Your protection and defense is in retaining childhood, and as I said, a part of you is afraid of giving up this protection. For you, the key question at this point is: "Why am I afraid of no longer being a child?" The inner peace is the result of your work which makes you, at least partly, prepared to give up childhood.

QUESTION: You said some time ago that the result of the defense mechanism can be determined also by the effect it has on other people. I don't know whether I really understand that correctly, but occasionally I find that my defense mechanism is perfect and that the effect it has on the other person is wonderful.

ANSWER: For what you really want or for what you think you want?

QUESTION: For what I think I want. If I follow through with a defense to keep people from meddling with my affairs, they are most happy, everyone else is happy, so it is not the other person who reacts badly to my defense mechanism.

ANSWER: In the first place, the question arises here that outwardly you may be content with the result, but you overlook necessary by-products of it that make you far from happy. And even if others do not seem to mind how a particular defense you are thinking of affects them, it has adverse results for you whether you now realize it or not. Only increased self-understanding will make this clear to you. You may be thinking of one separated, isolated aspect of it, while I talk about the

entirety, with all its results, of which you have no inkling as yet. This is something one becomes aware of gradually after a great deal of work. You may be aware of some isolated aspects of it.

Moreover, what may happen here is just what I discussed in this lecture. You are aware of a part of your image claim which is fulfillable because in itself it is not based on an erroneous assumption. But you are still unaware of the underlying claim which leaves you unfulfilled. Find the unpronounced claim and desire, the heretofore repressed need that you have neglected, and you will see how your defense mechanism prohibits your deepest goals and desires. You will understand how you inhibit yourself from bringing out all that is still dormant in you, all your potentials that cannot be unfolded with the defense mechanism that you think works so well for you.

QUESTION: Would you give also an example of how to relinquish a need, as you indicated so clearly by the example of how to get the real needs fulfilled?

ANSWER: Let us take the case I used tonight as a hypothesis. The real need of this person is to be loved, to love, to have a real meaningful relationship. He is unaware of this need. The childhood experiences with their effect on this particular personality have prohibited the unfoldment of the personality which would bring about fulfillment. He has repressed knowledge of this need. Instead, he pursues success, approval, impressing others. This then has become a superimposed, false need, covering up the real need. To begin with, he is not fully aware of his need for approval. But let us assume such a person follows a path of this sort. He will first become aware of the tremendous drive for success, surpassing his rational explanation for it. He will slowly realize that a stronger force urges him on and on. First he will not understand it, but as he is more willing to examine his emotions, he will see that his need for approval exists. To stop at this point will not yield relief and liberation. It is only a part of the way. But by going on, he will ask himself why he needs success so badly. The answer will be that approval is very important for him. Why is it so important? By consulting his emotions very honestly, without resistance, he will finally see that his need for love has been denied as a child, and he has gone on denying it himself by way of the image with all its by-products. The awareness of this real need, once it is truly felt and experienced with its full impact, will automatically diminish the drive for ambition, success, approval, impressing others, being glorious, special, and so on and on. He will do what he really wants and distribute his forces and resources in a more harmonious way. This does not by any means imply that he will all of a sudden neglect a healthy interest in his work. But harmony will gradually establish itself, and the inner aim will be directed towards that which he had neglected for so long. He will come to see how he sabotaged the fulfillment of his real need by the pursuit of the false need. He will clearly see the behavior pattern of the false need and how it damaged the real need. Therefore he will begin to change in that respect.

This is relinquishing in the real sense. One grows into it by insight, by full understanding of all the factors involved, and then no longer having to hold onto the false needs and the destructive defenses. But it can never be done by an action of will. If you find yourself beginning to recognize that similar trends exist and try forcefully to relinquish this need, it will do you no good. You will either not succeed, or the anxiety may be so great that you produce other destructive trends of which you are unaware. But to go through the slow process described just now, organic growth occurs, and the relinquishing happens in a natural way.

QUESTION: Now let us say a person has a number of real needs, as everybody has, and a number of artificial or false needs. They may not even be very strong. But how to go about it in a particular direction?

ANSWER: Well, I think this has been answered already, not only in the answer just given, but also by tonight's lecture. But let me add, when you observe your emotions with their inner, unpronounced claims, the behavior pattern resulting from it, if you observe your reactions to others and how you affect others; by consideration, from the way you act and react, of which needs are fulfilled and which remain unfulfilled, you will gain a clearer picture about the process under discussion tonight. Become aware of your emotions, your needs, and your defense, how they make you behave inwardly and therefore also outwardly. Be it only ever so subtle, you will clearly see the answer. In order to do so, a great deal of inner awareness has to be cultivated. This is best done by the path I advocate and I steadily lead you further on. Allow your emotions to come to the surface, and learn to cope with them. Understand their deeper meaning and their reason for being. Also, in the group work you now have, among other benefits, you get more understanding of how you affect others and how others affect you. When you feel your defense coming up, and when not, what is the difference in your perception, experience, ability to communicate with or without this defense -- all this will reveal your inner life to you. And this will help you to relinquish false needs and replace them with constructive behavior patterns, fulfilling your real needs.

My dearest friends, may these words find an echo in all of you, if not immediately, then after you have surged on a little further. Be blessed, each one of you. Rejoice on this path towards freedom. Do not let yourself be discouraged when you find yourself in a seeming impasse, temporarily, where the path is thorny and involved and it takes all your efforts to work yourself out of the thick shrubbery and see the light again. It will come. It is bound to come. Receive our warmth and our love and our blessings. Be in peace. Be in God!

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